

ing are FM recording and an equaliser, but the price is justified.

The Sony Network Walkman is an excellent product—the sound is good, the compression ratio is better, but that's about it. It provides 256 MB of storage space, and is priced at Rs 29,990, which is unjustifiable: you could buy six Transcends at the same cost and have 1.5 GB of space in your hands! And if you are not interested in solid-state players, you can always buy an iPod, which is still Rs 3,000 or 4,000 less than the Sony.

Conclusion

Infighting is common when there are lots of contenders for the throne. The Creative players fought it out amongst themselves, especially among the MuVo TX, Rhomba NX and the MuVo Slim. While one offered more space and data storage portability, the latter offered excellent audio quality with great features.

The MuVo Slim was one of the sleekest MP3 players we have ever tested. The Samsung Yepp YP-T5 offered a host of features including Line-in encoding, and also gave excellent audio performance. But it lost because of price.

Special mention is in order for the ACi Truly MP301 MP3 player. Not only did it sport the largest of all the displays, it also offered functionalities such as Line-in encoding and FM recording, not to mention support for text files and jpg images. The screen quality can be improved, but its flaunt value is extremely good. It retails at Rs 6,999, and provides 256 MB of space—but loses out on battery life. If you want an MP3 player that you would like to use for only around an hour a day, this one will definitely not disappoint you.

Finally, it was the Rhomba NX that won the Best Buy Gold, the reason being that we were primarily testing portable digital music players and not portable storage options. The Rhomba NX did not offer too much storage space, but it did offer excellent audio clarity.

Its intuitive menu and well

Flash-based audio players are suitable for your daily commutes and general listening

placed buttons, not to mention the FM sensitivity feature, took it through to be the winner of our MP3 players comparison. The Creative MuVo Slim won the Best Buy Silver award because of its good battery life, audio quality and sleek looks.

MICRO HARD DRIVE BASED PORTABLE AUDIO PLAYERS

Flash-based audio players are limited in terms of storage capacity, and are therefore mainly suitable for your daily commutes and general listening. However, if you are a frequent traveller or find that one or two hours of music just isn't enough, micro hard drive portable audio players are the solution for you. These devices offer a good balance between storage capacity and pocketability. Here we take a look at the Apple iPod Mini and three contenders from Creative.

Features

On the storage space front, the iPod Mini offers 4 GB, while the Creative MuVo2 is available in capacities of 1.5 GB and 4 GB. The MuVo2 FM offers 5 GB. The large display on the iPod Mini is a pleasure to use; it displays six lines at a time, making browsing through hundreds of tracks easier.

The Creatives only have a two-line display. The Creative MuVo2 FM is the only model in this category to be bundled with a wired remote. For the others, you would have to purchase one separately.

The MuVo2 FM also boasts of an FM tuner and voice recording capabilities, features not present on the other contenders.

In terms of playback features, the Creative devices provide standard equaliser presets and also allow you to set the equaliser manually. The iPod Mini does not have a customisable equaliser, but makes up for it by offering about 22 presets.

Support for music formats in the Mini is also impressive—it includes support for AAC, MP3, WAV and Audible, in comparison to the Creatives, which support MP3, WMA and WAV. Additional features on the iPod include an alarm, a calendar, Contacts, and games. However, the internal battery in the iPod is not user-replaceable, in contrast to the Creative MuVo2 devices.

Ergonomics And Ease Of Use

The Creative MuVo2 players are designed the same way—square, and just under a hundred grams in weight. However, with its tubular shape, the smooth-finished iPod Mini is definitely more pocketable. Housed in an aluminium casing, the Mini is also more solidly built compared to the MuVo2 players, which have a plastic body. All three Creative MuVo2 players have the same controls and interface.

With a five-way navigation button and a Play/Pause button on the front, the menu interface is simple and does not require you to refer to the manual. The five-way button is replaced with a joystick on the MuVo2 FM, which makes browsing a little easier. However, the two line display leaves much to be desired, as it is



Creative Rhomba NX



Creative MuVo Slim